

Title

Structured professional breastfeeding support reduces cessation and inequality: results from a cluster-randomized Danish implementation trial

Abstract

Though breastfeeding benefits are well-established, real-world support systems often fail to sustain lactation, particularly in economically disadvantaged populations. We implemented a coordinated, evidence-based breastfeeding-support initiative across 21 healthcare municipalities and evaluated its impact on lactation persistence and socioeconomic-related disparities. Health visitors and families in intervention clusters (n=11) received comprehensive training, standardized evidence-based protocols, family resource toolkits, and structured follow-up contacts; control clusters (n=10) continued customary support practices. Over 600 families and their health visitors completed structured assessments; implementation fidelity and quality were audited. In intervention areas, significantly more families maintained exclusive breastfeeding through six months postpartum. Importantly, socioeconomic-related disparities in breastfeeding cessation were substantially narrowed in intervention clusters while persisting in control regions. Health visitors in intervention clusters reported improved professional confidence and perceived the structured approach as fitting well within existing workflow. Qualitative interviews revealed minimal concerns about stigma despite intensive support targeting. These findings demonstrate that system-level professional breastfeeding support delivered through existing primary-care infrastructure can sustain lactation persistence and narrow equity gaps.